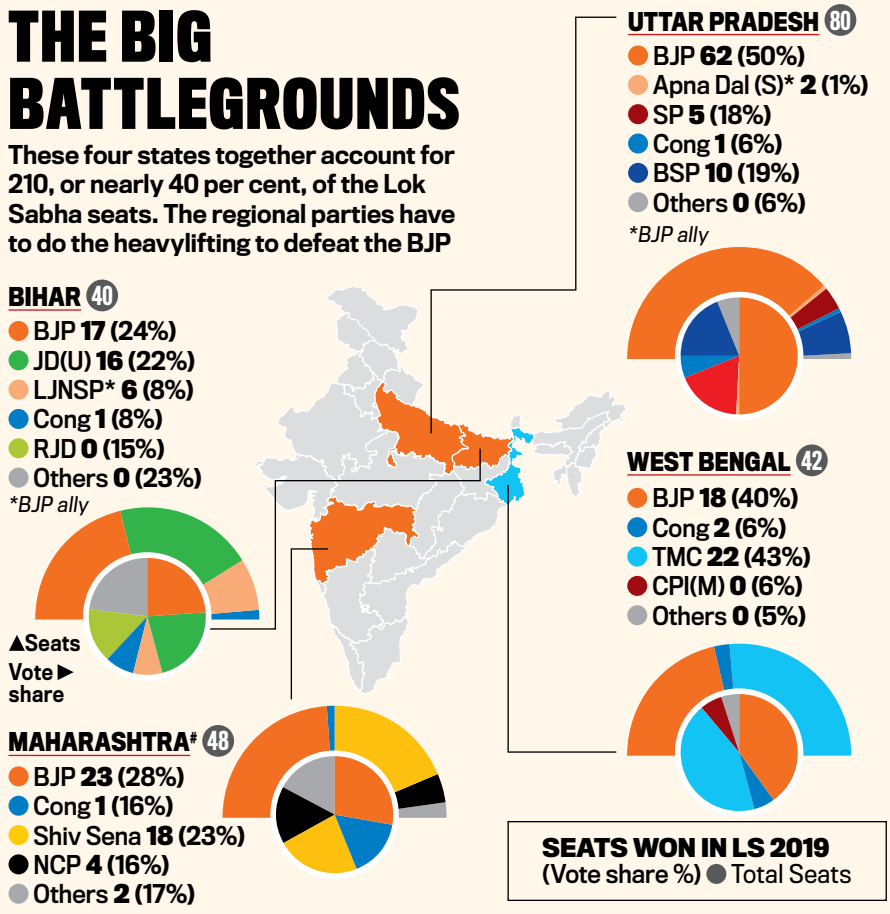
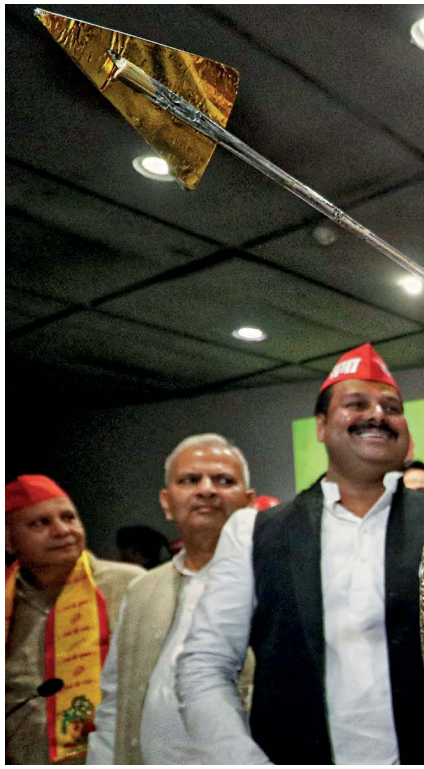
THE BIG BATTLEGROUNDS

These four states together account for 210, or nearly 40 per cent, of the Lok Sabha seats. The regional parties have to do the heavylifting to defeat the BJP



#In 2019, the Shiv Sena was part of the NDA and the NCP was with the UPA; after vertical splits in both parties, a faction each has now allied with the BJP and the Congress



ANI

Congress to bridge this gap," says political strategist and election analyst Amitabh Tiwari. In 125 out of the 421 seats the Congress contested in 2019, the party had lost by a margin of more than 15 percentage points. In 309 constituencies, the Congress has not won even once in the past three polls. In another 183, it has won only once. Of the 25 parliamentary seats in the Northeast, once a Congress stronghold, it now has just four in two states.

But if the Congress *can* mount a challenge in even a small critical mass of seats where it faces the BJP directly, it could hope to depress ruling party numbers below the 272 majority mark and diminish the Modi aura. In that endeavour, the Congress is sharpening three strategies. First, as the only party in I.N.D.I.A. with organisational presence across states, the party has been working towards weaving a coherent national narrative against the BJP. Congress scion Rahul Gandhi has since 2022 completed two yatras—one on foot, from south to north; the other by bus, from east to west. The impulse behind both yatras was the same: countering the BJP's "communal" politics, ensuring equitable growth focused on marginalised socio-economic sections, social justice for all and protecting the constitutional values of the country. The party has also kept up its relentless attack on the Modi government on unemployment, price rise and its alleged nexus with big corporate groups—never mind if issues such as threat to democracy or misuse of central agencies may have no tangible impact on voters given that most parties in India are guilty of such oversteps. "The Ram temple and direct transfer of benefits are tangible for voters. Threat to democracy is not," says Prof. Varun Chhachhar of Lucknow University. Mallikarjun Kharge, Congress president and I.N.D.I.A. convenor, feels otherwise (*see accompanying interview*). "There is already an undeclared Emergency," he tells INDIA TODAY. "Modi is an autocrat."

The Opposition may also still have a plank in the national caste census despite losing Nitish, who conducted a caste survey in Bihar, to the BJP. It will be crucial in Opposition attempts to woo the Other Backward Classes, who have been a mainstay of the BJP's electoral victories in recent times.

Secondly, the Congress, which won Karnataka last year on the back of the five guarantees it promised voters, is expanding on the theme to counter the 'Modi Guarantee' of a Viksit Bharat (developed India) by 2047. It is hoping to attract the socially backward classes, farmers, women and youth with 25 guarantees, including a caste census, removing the 50 per cent cap on reservations, appointments to 3 million government posts, apprenticeship with an annual stipend of Rs 1 lakh to every graduate and diploma-holder, a new law to curb paper leaks, Rs 1 lakh a